

THE FL

■ By Swagata Sen in Aizawl

The flowering of bamboo sends Mizoram into a terrifying spiral of crop devastation and food shortages. The last time the bamboo bloomed 48 years ago, it led to famine and two decades of violent insurgency.

In the late afternoon sun, the entire village of Khanpui in Mizoram gathers around the wooden local primary school shed. Huddled in the chill as winter sets in, they look over the hills at Aizawl, glittering in the distance. It is 100 km and a world away from the state capital, separated by miles and miles of devastated crops and dried bamboo forests. A village elder starts praying, "Lord, give us the strength to survive this *mautam*, this famine unleashed on us due to the bamboo flowering."

In dozens of even more remote villages across Mizoram, no one can ignore the frightening legend of the flowering of the bamboo. They say that when the bamboo flowers once every 48 years, it brings along with it death, destruction and suffering. In the fertile southernmost state of north-east India, that time is now.

Not a single paddy stalk has been harvested in Khanpui and the rest of Mizoram as well. The flowering of one particular species of bamboo—*Melocanna baccifera*, locally known as *mautak*—has set in motion the frightening spiral that happens every 48 years in the state. The bamboo flower brings with it hordes of rodents, bugs and locusts, which multiply after eating the nutritious bamboo fruit. All that is

When the bamboo flowers,

Graphic by RAM

SWEET TOOTH Rats relish the fruit borne by the bamboo because of its high starch content of around 50 per cent



INFESTATION Increased availability of food results in manifold rise of rodent population